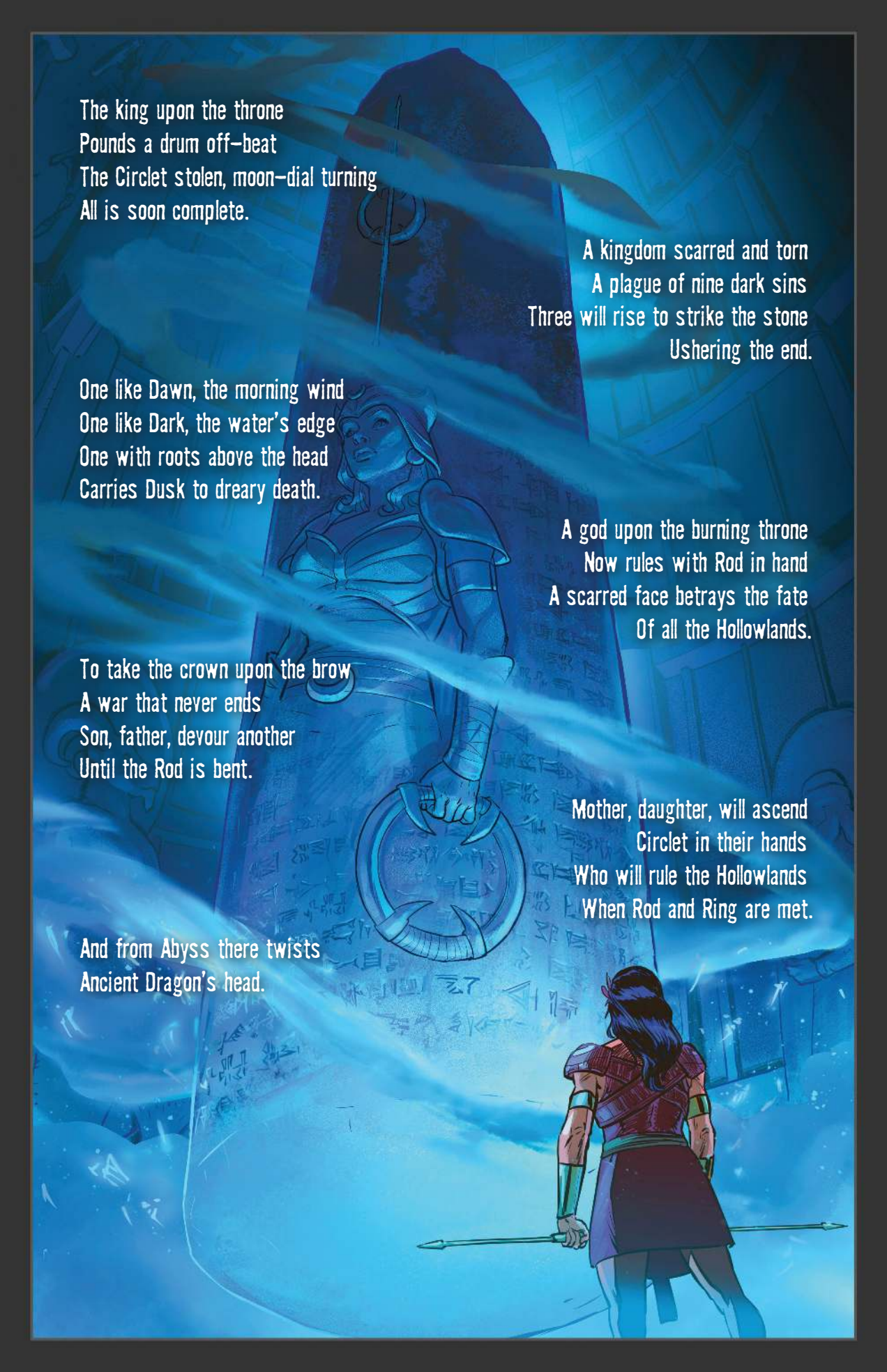


CHAPTER 2





The king upon the throne
Pounds a drum off-beat
The Circlet stolen, moon-dial turning
All is soon complete.

A kingdom scarred and torn
A plague of nine dark sins
Three will rise to strike the stone
Ushering the end.

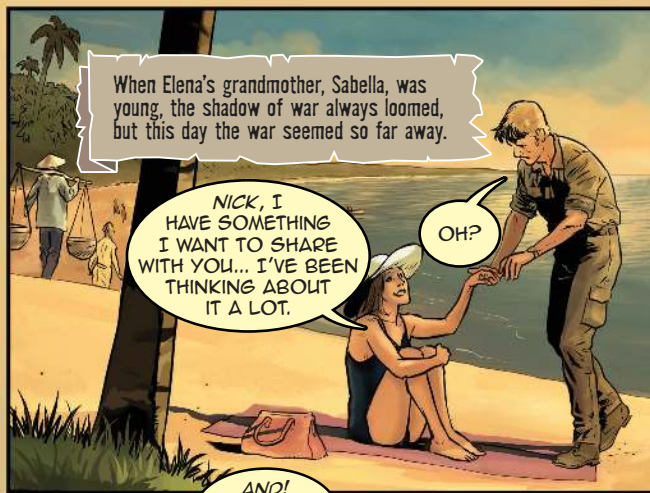
One like Dawn, the morning wind
One like Dark, the water's edge
One with roots above the head
Carries Dusk to dreary death.

A god upon the burning throne
Now rules with Rod in hand
A scarred face betrays the fate
Of all the Hollowlands.

To take the crown upon the brow
A war that never ends
Son, father, devour another
Until the Rod is bent.

Mother, daughter, will ascend
Circlet in their hands
Who will rule the Hollowlands
When Rod and Ring are met.

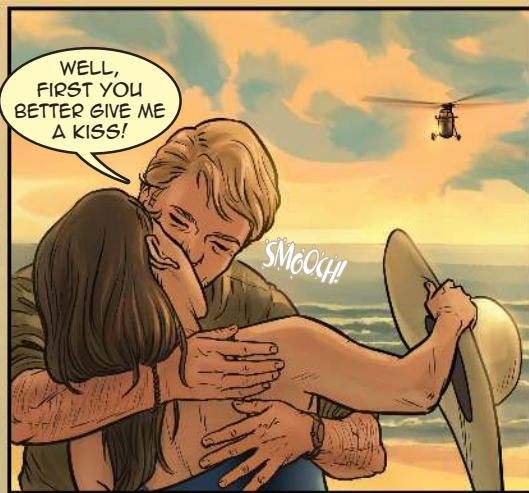
And from Abyss there twists
Ancient Dragon's head.



When Elena's grandmother, Sabella, was young, the shadow of war always loomed, but this day the war seemed so far away.

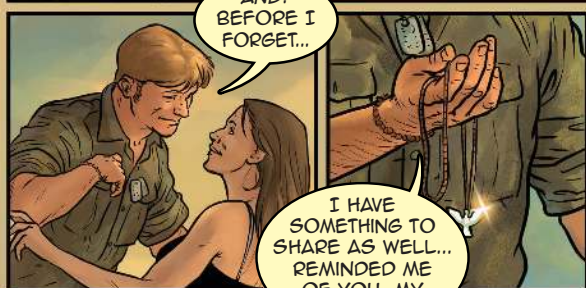
NICK, I HAVE SOMETHING I WANT TO SHARE WITH YOU... I'VE BEEN THINKING ABOUT IT A LOT.

OH?



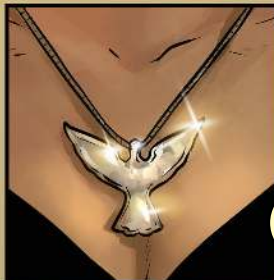
WELL, FIRST YOU BETTER GIVE ME A KISS!

SMOOCH!



AND! BEFORE I FORGET...

I HAVE SOMETHING TO SHARE AS WELL... REMINDED ME OF YOU, MY DOVE.



HONEY... THANK YOU!



These moments of paradise were fleeting, and then...

SORRY TO INTERRUPT YOU TWO LOVE-BIRDS... WE HAVE AN URGENT SITUATION... WE'LL NEED YOU ON POINT, NICK.

DO YOU SEE WHAT I HAVE TO PUT UP WITH, LOVE? COMPLETE INCOMPETENCY. THEY ALWAYS NEED ME TO HOLD THEIR HAND.



I'LL TELL HIM NEXT TIME THAT I'M PREGNANT.



PLEASE, PLEASE, BE SAFE OUT THERE, LOVE.

...they were gone like the wind's dust.



But the wind carries many things,
and so it bore two travelers into
the shadow...

WHAT
A PRETTY
DOVE...

AHH!...
AND WHAT
A TERRIFYING
CREATURE FROM
MY DARKEST
NIGHTMARE!

ELENA,
WE MUST MAKE
CAMP SOON AND
IT IS BETTER HERE
THAN IN THE OPEN
GRASSLANDS.

SKWOOP



...of the footstool of the gods.

WHAT
IS THIS
PLACE?

NOTHING
MUCH NOW...
USED TO BE
GLORIOUS.



AND
WE'RE JUST
GONNA CAMP
OUTSIDE OF THE
TOTALLY NOT
INTERESTING
TOWER?

WHAT IS
IN THERE? I
SEE SOME
LIGHT

NO. PLEASE,
DO NOT GET ANY
IDEAS. THE TOWER IS
CURSED. BUT ITS LIGHT
DOES KEEP AWAY
UNWANTED PESTS
AT NIGHT.



AW,
C'MON, NO
TOUR?

UNLESS
YOU WANT US
TO BE CURSED
BY THE NINE, IT IS
VERY BAD LUCK TO
TREAD ON THAT
GROUND



THE
NINE? THE
NINE WHAT?
KINGS?

THERE
ARE NINE
CRUEL GODS
ATRUS NUL
SERVES...

ESPECIALLY
IRRA, GOD OF WAR...
CROSS THEIR
SERVANTS, AND YOU
DON'T GET A
WARNING.

SO THERE
WAS A BIG WAR
OR
SOMETHING?

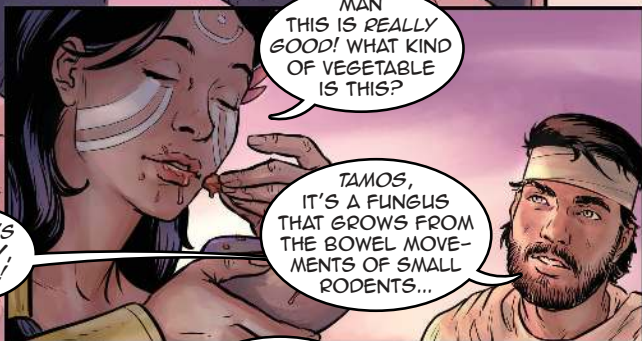
NOT A WAR.
A MASSACRE,
THE MAGUS WERE
SCHOLARS, NOT
SOLDIERS. KEEPERS OF
ANCIENT WISDOM. THEIR
SPIRITS STILL
DO NOT SLEEP.



YOU
MEAN LIKE
THESE GUYS
WITH THE
LONG PONY
TAILS?

YES. ADVISORS
TO THE OLD KINGS,
THEN THE TITAN LORDS.
THEY REBELLED.
ATRUS NUL HUNTED THEM
DOWN ONE BY ONE.
THE MAGUS ARE NOTHING
BUT A MEMORY
NOW.

DINNER'S
READY,
ELENA!



MAN
THIS IS REALLY
GOOD! WHAT KIND
OF VEGETABLE
IS THIS?

TAMOS,
IT'S A FUNGUS
THAT GROWS FROM
THE BOWEL MOVE-
MENTS OF SMALL
RODENTS...



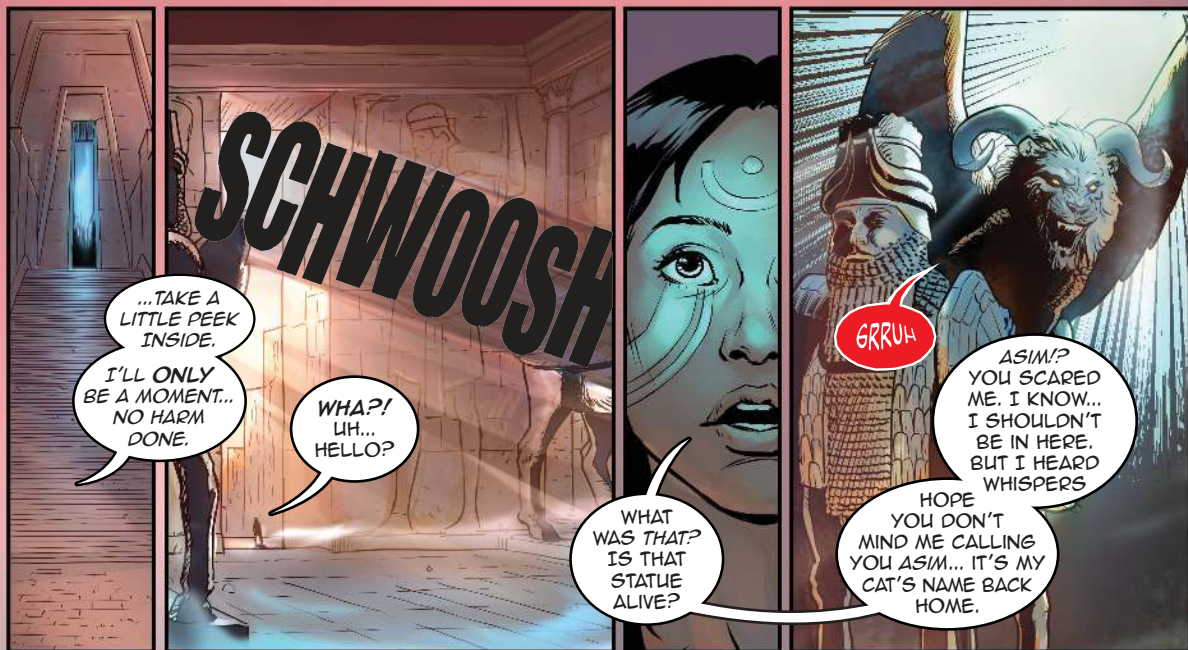
HEY!
YOU WOULD
DO WELL NOT TO
WASTE GOOD FOOD!
HERE, LET ME FETCH
YOU SOME
WATER.

ELENA,
STAY HERE
OK?

BLECK!



OK, OK,
NO TOWER,
GOT IT. WEIRD... DO
I HEAR WHISPERS
FROM... I'LL
JUST...



...TAKE A
LITTLE PEEK
INSIDE.

I'LL ONLY
BE A MOMENT...
NO HARM
DONE.

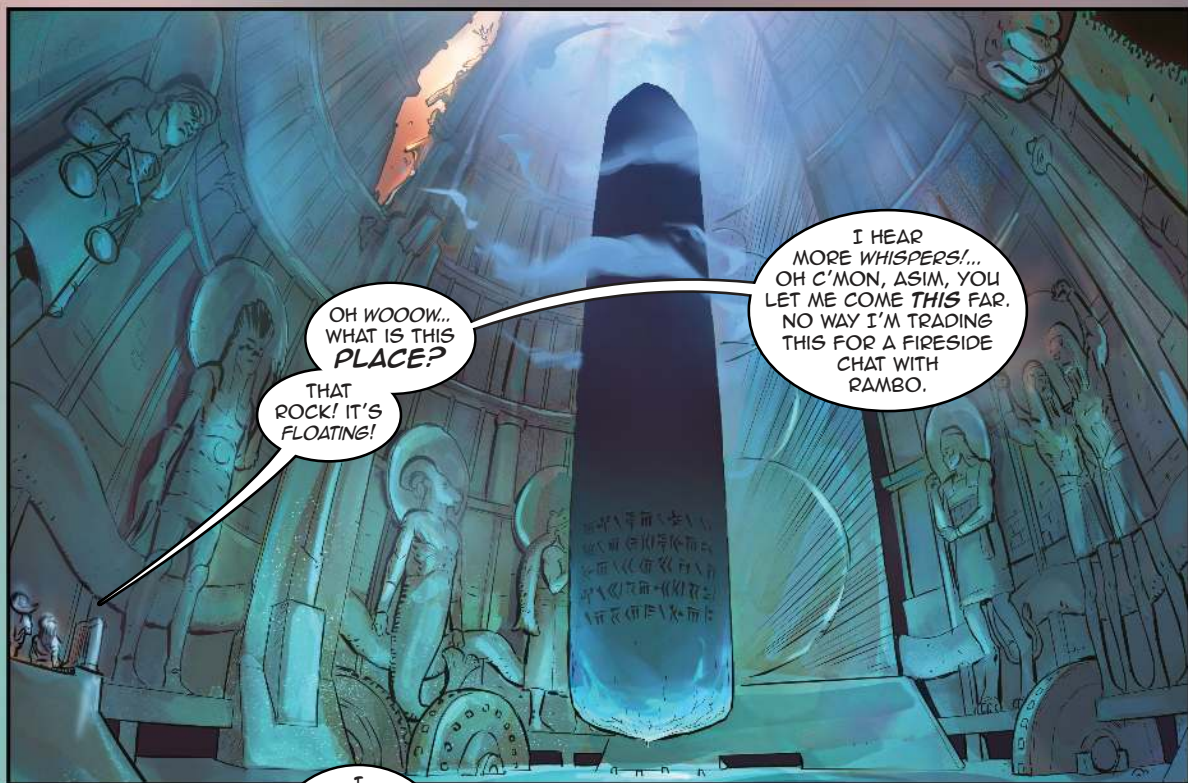
WHA?!
UH...
HELLO?

WHAT
WAS THAT?
IS THAT
STATUE
ALIVE?

GRRUH

ASIM?
YOU SCARED
ME. I KNOW...
I SHOULDN'T
BE IN HERE.
BUT I HEARD
WHISPERS

HOPE
YOU DON'T
MIND ME CALLING
YOU ASIM... IT'S MY
CAT'S NAME BACK
HOME.



OH WOOOW...
WHAT IS THIS
PLACE?

THAT
ROCK! IT'S
FLOATING!

I HEAR
MORE WHISPERS!...
OH C'MON, ASIM, YOU
LET ME COME **THIS** FAR.
NO WAY I'M TRADING
THIS FOR A FIRESIDE
CHAT WITH
RAMBO.



I
WONDER
IF THESE ARE
THE STATUES
OF THE
NINE?



GRRUH

WOAH!
I CAN
SEE THE
CRACKS.



It is said... our shadows are darkest
when the light burns brightest...

BY
THE GODS...
IF I COULD ONLY
REMEMBER WHAT
HAPPENED
BEFORE.

MY
HEAD...
IT PAINS
ME.



UH! OH...
IT'S YOU. WHY
DO YOU HAUNT
ME, SPIRIT!?

YOU
MUST COMPLETE
THE TASK WE
STARTED,
UTU.



WHY MUST
YOU HARASS ME?
HAVE YOU NOT TAKEN
ENOUGH FROM ME?
THIS IS NOT MY
BURDEN.

And all too often, it is the shadow
in the soul...



...that is darkest of all.

WHERE
DID SHE GO?
ELENA!?



YOU
MUST FIND
HER, UTU,
BEFORE
SHE...

The Maxim Stone, which floated above dials and gears, then revealed its great age by the souls, often the Sightless, that drift through its cracked facade from other realms.

THE
SYMBOLS...
THEY LOOK LIKE
THE ONES ON MY
WEAPON.

THIS
PLACE IS
CREEPY, ASIM.
WHAT ARE THOSE
PEDESTAL THINGS
NEAR THE
CENTER?

IT
LOOKS LIKE
IT FITS RIGHT
H-WOAH!

WSHSH
WSHH

KSHUNK

KSHUNK

SWEET
ONE, I KNEW
THAT YOU WOULD
FIND YOUR WAY
HERE.

GRAND-
MOTHER?
IS THAT YOU?
YOU LOOK MUCH
YOUNGER.

HER
IMAGE IS
FADING! WAIT...
HOW DO I FIND
YOU?

ELENA,
PREPARE YOUR-
SELF; A GREAT TRIAL
APPROACHES! THE
BLOOD MOON IS
RISING! I MUST
GO NOW....

GREAT...
JUST LIKE
THAT. SHE'S
GONE!

WAIT...
ARE THOSE
PIECES OF THE
FLOATING
STONE!?

TEK...TEK



Elena could not have known that an unseen power had awakened, forcing the machine into painful motion. And now... that hideous clock was ticking.

IT HAS NOW
BEGIN!

UHH...
ASIM... IS THIS
SUPPOSED TO BE
HAPPENING?

TEK...TEK

IT IS
NOT TIME!
SHE MUST BE
STOPPED!



GRRRR

TEK...TEK

ROAAARR



WHAT
IN THE?







SIGH...FORGIVE ME, ELENA. THE MAXIM STONE HAS BEEN WEAKENING FOR MANY CENTURIES. WHEN IT LOSES ITS POWER, THAT WILL MARK THE BEGINNING OF THE END OF THIS WORLD AND YOURS.

NOW I SEE WHY YOU YELLED. I'M SORRY, UTU.

IT IS ALRIGHT... HERE, I THINK YOU SHOULD WEAR **THIS**. I WAS ONCE THE LEADER OF A SMALL REBEL GROUP THAT FOUGHT THE DOMINION.

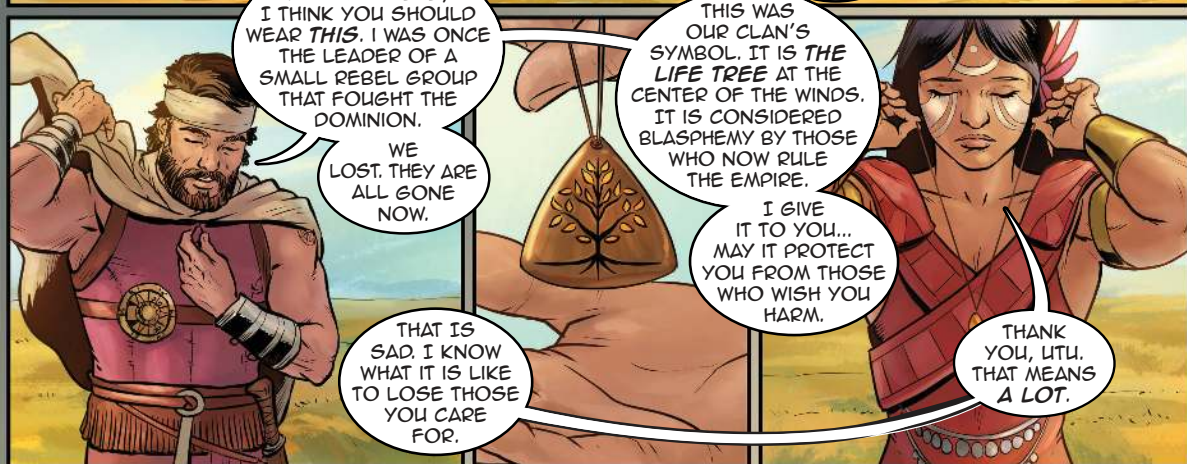
WE LOST. THEY ARE ALL GONE NOW.

THAT IS SAD. I KNOW WHAT IT IS LIKE TO LOSE THOSE YOU CARE FOR.

THIS WAS OUR CLAN'S SYMBOL. IT IS **THE LIFE TREE** AT THE CENTER OF THE WINDS. IT IS CONSIDERED BLASPHEMY BY THOSE WHO NOW RULE THE EMPIRE.

I GIVE IT TO YOU... MAY IT PROTECT YOU FROM THOSE WHO WISH YOU HARM.

THANK YOU, UTU. THAT MEANS A LOT.



WE CAN ASK. SIR!? SIR?!

EHP?

UGH... MY LEGS ACHE... MAYBE WE CAN HITCH A RIDE WITH THAT FARMER?



LOOK! THAT HOUSE... IT'S ON FIRE!

BY THE GODS... I HOPE THIS IS NOT ANOTHER DOMINION INQUEST!



WE MUST BE CAUTIOUS. NO MORE RUNNING OFF ON YOUR OWN. I MEAN IT.

I WON'T... I REALLY DON'T KNOW WHAT CAME OVER ME BACK THERE. I'M USUALLY KIND OF A CHICKEN.

HEY, LET'S BORROW SOME OF THESE CLOTHES TO BLEND IN.

A SENSIBLE IDEA, ELENA. GOOD THINKING!



NAMIN...
I KNOW THIS
INQUISITOR.

WHY ARE
THEY DOING
THIS?

WE WILL
NOT ASK AGAIN,
APOSTATE.
WHERE IS THE
MAGUS?

PLEASE,
PLEASE, STOP
THIS. WE DON'T
KNOW. WE
DON'T KN-



HE HAS
CHOSEN
TO SUFFER...
PROCEED!



THWAK



ENOUGH!
I AM THE MAN
YOU WANT. YOU HAVE
ME NOW. LET THE
OTHERS GO.



YOU
HAVE MADE A
WISE DECISION...
GUARDS, SEIZE
THIS MAN!



WE
HAVE TO DO
SOMETHING,
UTU.

NO WE
DON'T. DO
NOT TELL ME
YOU HAVE
A—

I
HAVE A
PLAN.



HUH!?

FATHER!
THERE YOU
ARE! WE NEED
TO GET YOU
HOME!



I
DO NOT
HAVE TIME FOR
THIS. KILL
HER!



WAIT! MY
FATHER IS NOT
WELL. HE WANDERED
FROM OUR
HOME.



L-LORD
ORION!

I...I...DID
NOT SEE YOU
ARRIVE. THIS-THIS MAN
IS WITH THE SEDITIONIST
GROUP. HE IS A MAGUS,
AND WE HAVE
BEEN...

WHAT IS
THE MEANING
OF ALL OF THIS
THEN?!

I SEE NO
MAGUS HERE! GO
NOW, WHILE YOU STILL
CAN! LEAVE THESE PEOPLE
BE. UNLESS... YOU
WISH TO CALL ME
A LIAR?!

WHAT
THE—

YOU ARE
DECEIVED, MY
LORD! DECEIVED
BUT... WE HAVE OTHER
BUSINESS TO
ATTEND TO...
WE GO!



LORD
ATRUS NUL
WILL HEAR
OF THIS



SIGH...
I DID NOT MEAN
TO BRING HARM TO THE
GOOD PEOPLE OF THIS
TOWN... I AM IN YOUR
DEBT... MANY
THANKS.

OF
COURSE...
WAIT... YOU REALLY
ARE THE FUGITIVE
MAGUS, AREN'T
YOU?





AHH...
THE QUEEN...
SHE SIMPLY ADORED
THESE FLOWERS.
WELL, USED
TO... OH!

SORRY,
BUT WILL
THE ORACLE
BE HERE
SOON?

I'M
TOO OLD AND
DISHEVELED,
HMMM?



WAIT...
YOU ARE ISIN
ADA?

I AM
SHE. AND YOU...
YOU ARE FROM THE
OTHER SIDE, **AREN'T**
YOU? WE HAVE GRAVE
THINGS TO DISCUSS,
BEARER OF THE
MARK.



WOAH!... SOME
KIND OF MAGICAL
POOL... THAT'S HER... SHE
LOOKS YOUNGER AND
POWERFUL.

I BELIEVE
THIS IS THE WOMAN
YOU'RE LOOKING FOR?
SHE WAS ONCE OUR
QUEEN.

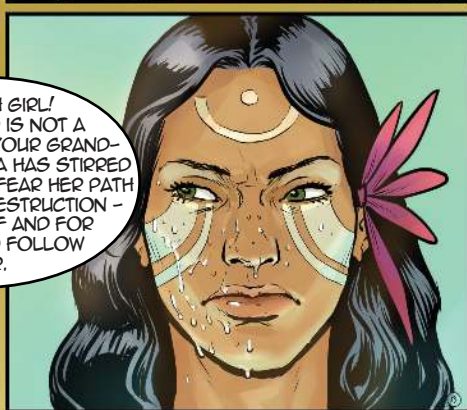
WAR HAS
CHANGED HER...
GONE ARE THE DAYS
WHEN THE WIND GUIDED
HER. SHE WALKS THE PATH
OF THE MOON NOW...
BUT I KNOW WHERE
SHE MAY BE
FOUND.



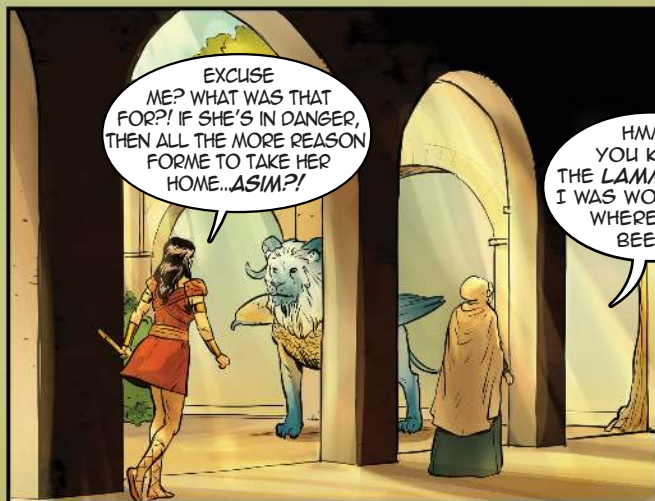
I
CANNOT
WAIT TO SEE
HER!



UGH!?



FOOLISH GIRL!
THIS WORLD IS NOT A
PLAYGROUND! YOUR GRAND-
MOTHER SABELLA HAS STIRRED
DARK WATERS! I FEAR HER PATH
WILL LEAD TO DESTRUCTION -
FOR HERSELF AND FOR
THOSE WHO FOLLOW
HER.



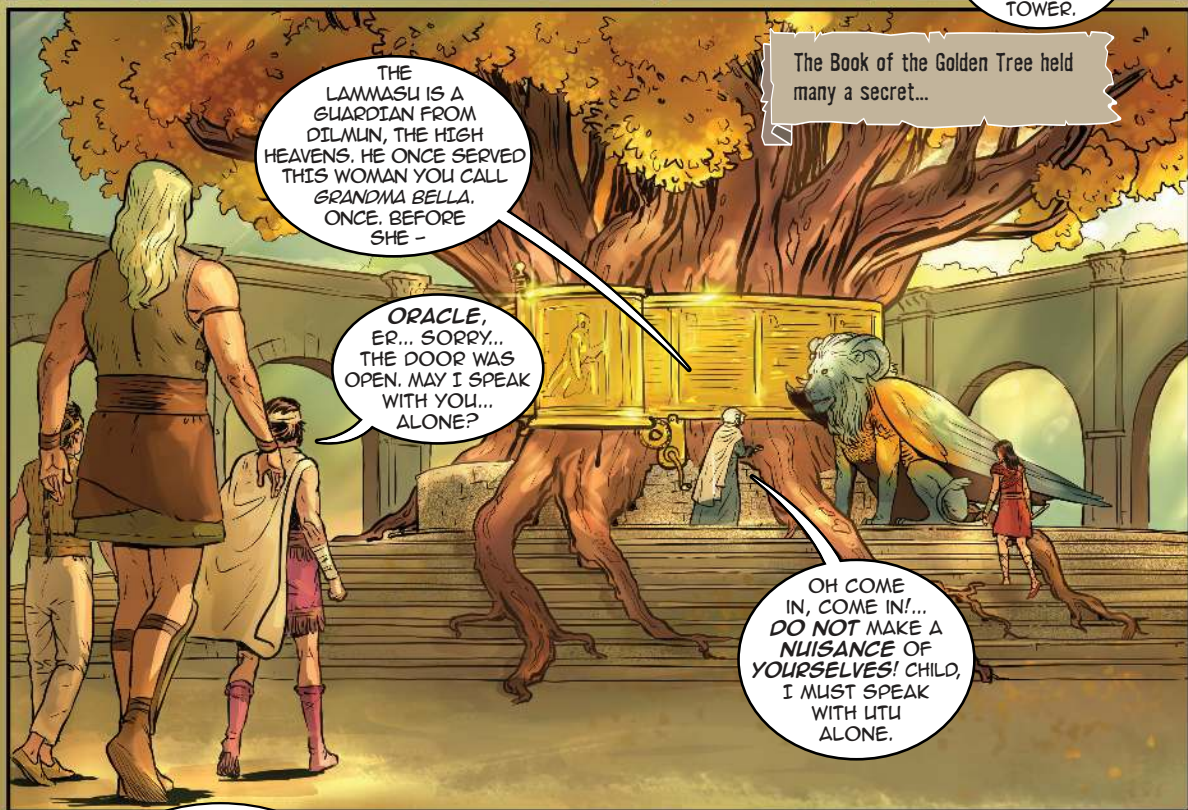
EXCUSE ME? WHAT WAS THAT FOR? IF SHE'S IN DANGER, THEN ALL THE MORE REASON FORME TO TAKE HER HOME...*ASIM?*!

HMM? YOU KNOW THE LAMMASSU? I WAS WONDERING WHERE HE'D BEEN...



MRRRR

I THOUGHT YOU HAD LEFT FOR GOOD BACK AT THE TOWER.



THE LAMMASSU IS A GUARDIAN FROM DILMUN, THE HIGH HEAVENS. HE ONCE SERVED THIS WOMAN YOU CALL GRANDMA BELLA. ONCE. BEFORE SHE -

ORACLE, ER... SORRY... THE DOOR WAS OPEN. MAY I SPEAK WITH YOU... ALONE?

The Book of the Golden Tree held many a secret...

OH COME IN, COME IN!... DO NOT MAKE A NUISANCE OF YOURSELVES! CHILD, I MUST SPEAK WITH LUTU ALONE.

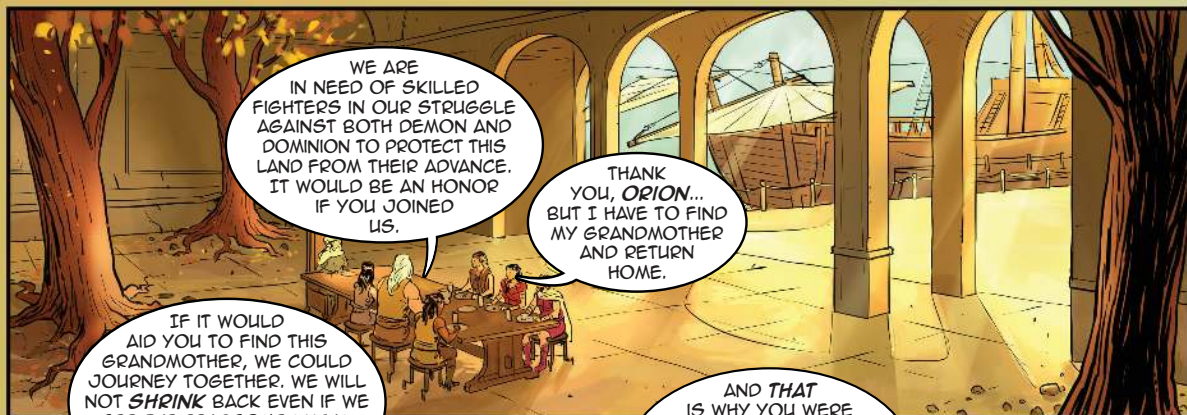


ISIN ADA, MUCH HAS HAPPENED! THE GIRL HAS ACCIDENTALLY AWAKENED THE MOON CLOCK BENEATH THE MAXIM STONE! THE LUGAL WILL BE SEARCHING FOR HER... AND FOR THAT WHICH SHE CARRIES, WE MUST DESTROY IT!

THE DAWN SPEAR... THEN THE END IS NOW ON THE HORIZON. NO, LUTU. WE WILL NOT DESTROY IT. WE WILL TRAIN HER.



COME NOW! LET US EAT! YOU ALL MUST HAVE SUSTENANCE FOR THE JOURNEY AHEAD!



WE ARE
IN NEED OF SKILLED
FIGHTERS IN OUR STRUGGLE
AGAINST BOTH DEMON AND
DOMINION TO PROTECT THIS
LAND FROM THEIR ADVANCE.
IT WOULD BE AN HONOR
IF YOU JOINED
US.

THANK
YOU, **ORION**...
BUT I HAVE TO FIND
MY GRANDMOTHER
AND RETURN
HOME.

IF IT WOULD
AID YOU TO FIND THIS
GRANDMOTHER, WE COULD
JOURNEY TOGETHER. WE WILL
NOT **SHRINK** BACK EVEN IF WE
SEE THE FEARSOME LUGAL
HIMSELF. WE HAVE BEEN A
THORN IN HIS SIDE AND
WILL BE **AGAIN**.

AND **THAT**
IS WHY YOU WERE
EXILED IN THE **FIRST**
PLACE, **ORION**. YOU ARE FAR
TOO **BRASH**, BUT IT WOULD
NOT HURT TO HAVE
SOME ADDED
SECURITY.

PERHAPS I
CAN HELP? YOU MAY
TAKE MY OLD **SKY SKIFF**...
THAT COULD HELP MAKE
THE JOURNEY FAR
ABOVE THAT DEADLY
WILDERNESS.



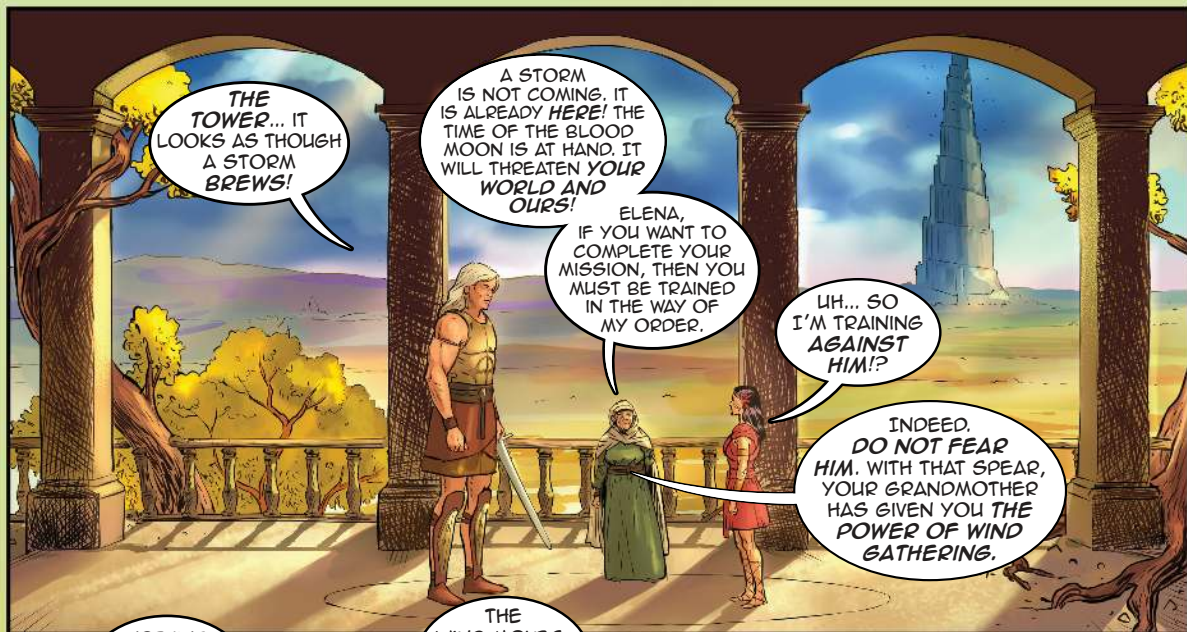
VERY
WELL, **ISIN ADA**.
I WILL SUPPLY US
WITH A CREW AND
SUPPLIES FOR THE
JOURNEY.

THE
SKY PATH
LEADS OVER THE
WESTERN WILDERNESS
TO THE CITY OF
SINN, WHERE THE
MOON QUEEN
PRESIDES.

IF THERE
IS A CHANCE OF A
FIGHT, YOU CAN COUNT
ON ME AND MY
WARRIORS.



I FEAR
THERE'S MORE
THAN JUST A **CHANCE**.
WHILE ON THE RUN, I
RECEIVED WORD THAT
ATRUS NUL'S FORCES ARE
MARCHING ON THE **MOON**
CITY! I ONLY HOPE WE
ARE NOT TOO
LATE!



THE
TOWER... IT
LOOKS AS THOUGH
A STORM
BREWS!

A STORM
IS NOT COMING. IT
IS ALREADY **HERE!** THE
TIME OF THE BLOOD
MOON IS AT HAND. IT
WILL THREATEN YOUR
WORLD AND
OURS!

ELENA,
IF YOU WANT TO
COMPLETE YOUR
MISSION, THEN YOU
MUST BE TRAINED
IN THE WAY OF
MY ORDER.

UH... SO
I'M TRAINING
AGAINST
HIM?!

INDEED.
DO NOT FEAR
HIM. WITH THAT SPEAR,
YOUR GRANDMOTHER
HAS GIVEN YOU THE
POWER OF WIND
GATHERING.



NOTHING
TO WORRY
ABOUT. JUST A
HUGE GIANT
MAN.

THE
WIND MOVES,
THEN YOU ACT
IN UNISON.
READY!?

I'M
STRONGER
THAN YOU—THERE'S NO
GETTING AROUND THAT.
YOU MUST LEARN TO
BE **FASTER** AND
SMARTER.



NOT A
GOOD PLAN,
ELENA!

WHAT... AM...
I DOING?

LET YOUR
REACTION BE-
COME ONE WITH
THE ACTION.

YES,
YES, BEND WITH
THE WIND, DAUGHTER
OF DAWN. STEEL
YOURSELF WITH THE
LIGHT. CAN YOU
FEEL IT?!



UGH!

OW!
YES! I SURE
DID FEEL
IT.

WOW!...I
ACTUALLY DID
FEEL SOMETHING
FLOW THROUGH ME...
HOW DID I DEFEND
MYSELF SO
FAST!?

CLANG!



UGH!
IMPRESSIVE
SPEED AND
ACCURACY!

WHEN
THE WIND MOVES
YOU, THERE IS ONLY
CONFIDENT ACTION
AND EVEN YOUR
FEARS CANNOT
RESIST!!



GOOD...
GOOD!
THAT'S
IT!

THE
WIND **DOES**
INDEED MOVE
IN THIS ONE,
ORACLE!



THE MOON
QUEEN, YOUR
GRANDMOTHER, HAS
GROWN IN POWER. I
FEAR SHE HAS BORROWED
THE POWER OF NINGAL,
THE GODDESS OF THE
UNDERWORLD
HERSELF.

I HOPE
NOT. IF YOU CAN
REACH HER, MAYBE
YOU CAN BRING HER
BACK FROM THIS
FOLLY.

NO, NO,
GODDESS OF THE
UNDERWORLD?
SHE WOULDN'T
DO THAT.

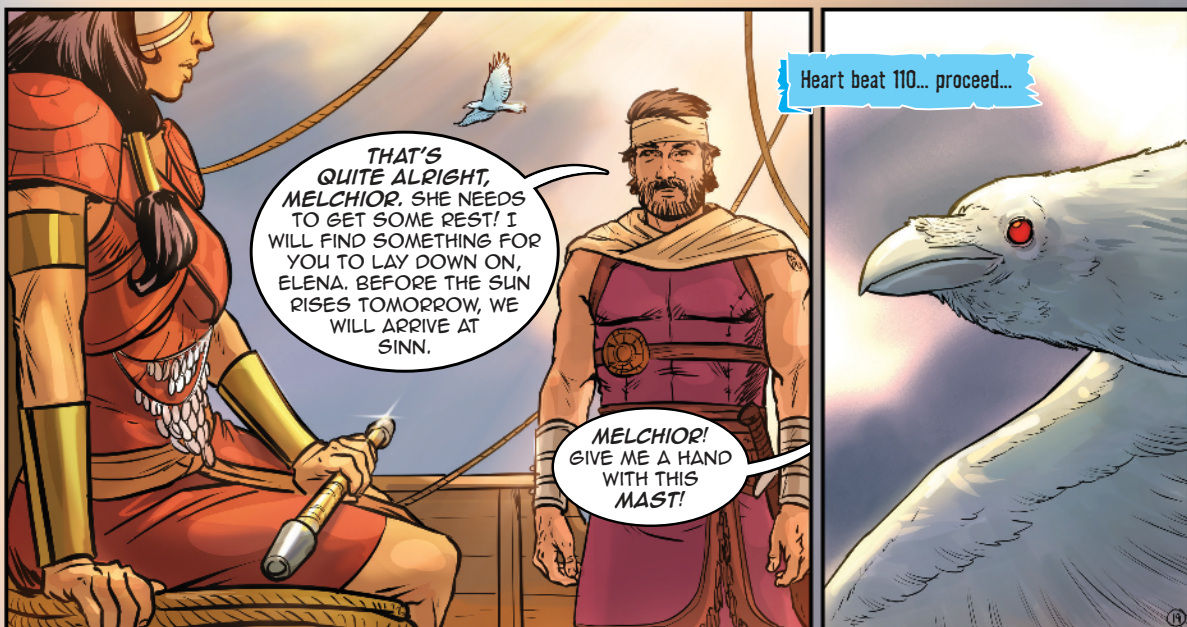
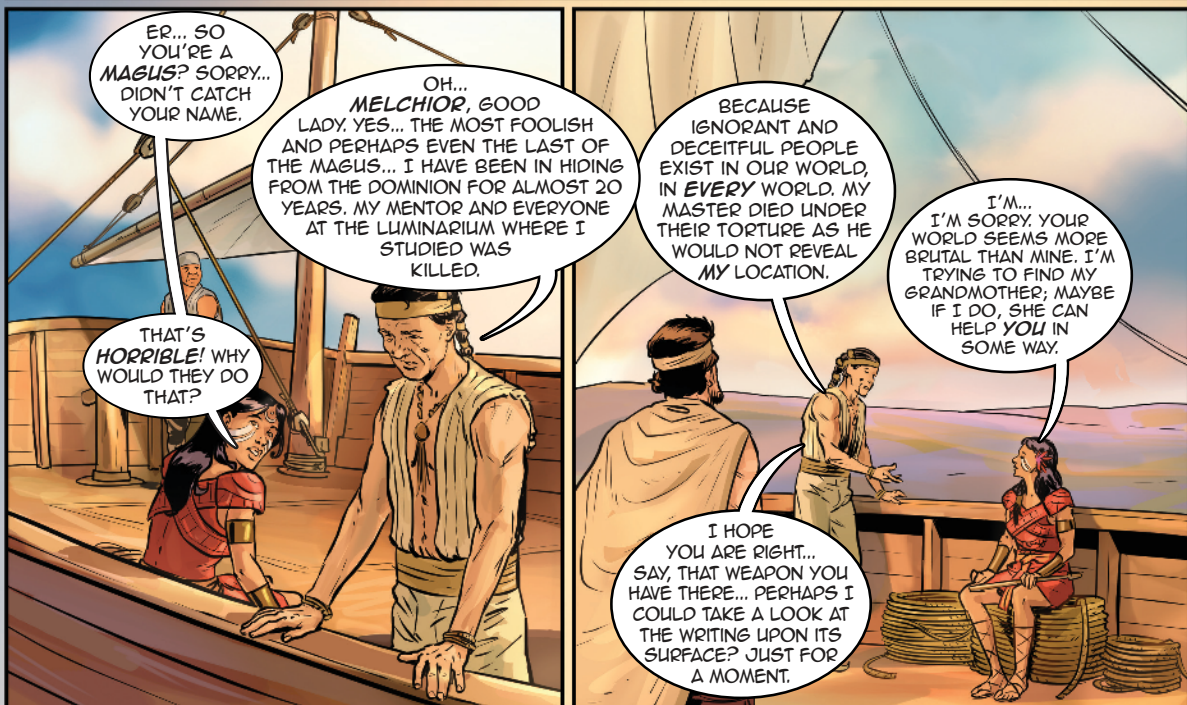
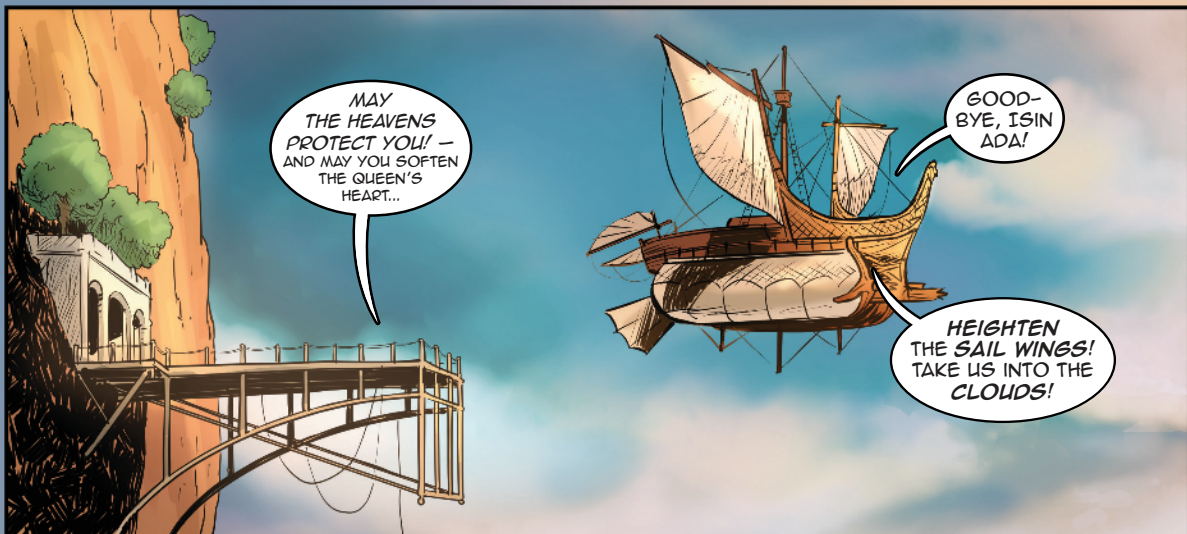
HMM...
ROD AND RING?
ANCIENT SYMBOLS OF
KINGSHIP? I REMEMBER
READING THIS IN ART HISTORY
BUT SURELY GRANDMOTHER
KNOWS OF THIS
DANGER?

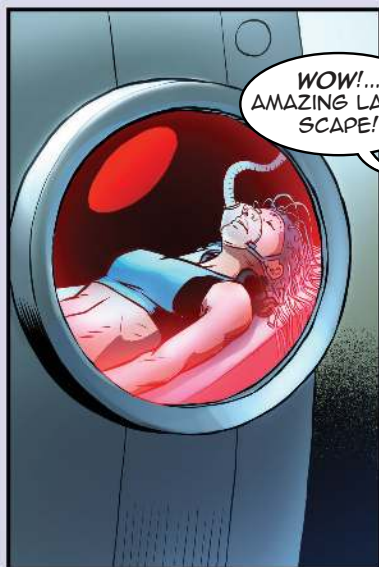
SHOULD
THE TWO RELICS
BE HELD BY THE SAME
PERSON... IT WOULD GRANT
THE WIELDER ALMOST
UNLIMITED POWER AND
THIS WOULD MEAN A
DIRE FUTURE FOR
BOTH OF OUR
WORLDS.

THE SKY
SKIFF IS READY TO
LEAVE... WHAT?
WHAT DID I MISS,
ELENA?

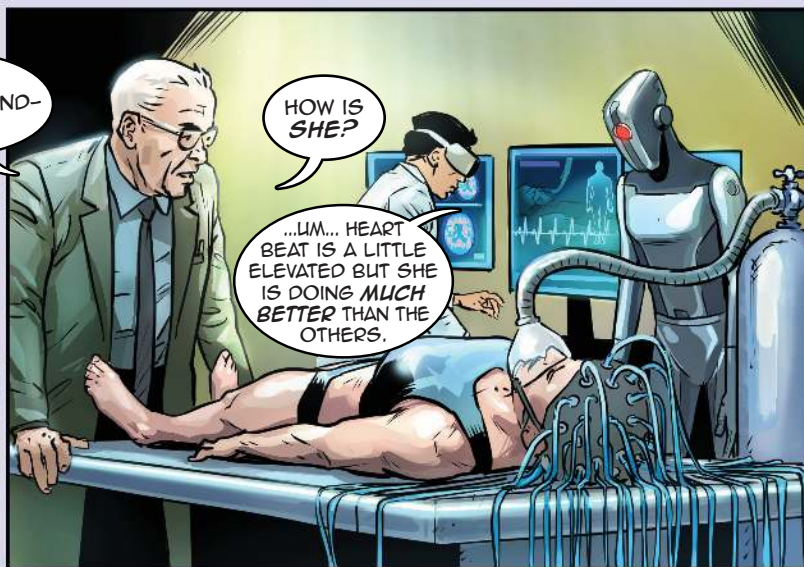
I'VE HEARD
WHISPERS THAT
THE MOON QUEEN
HOLDS THE RING
OF DARK,

AND THAT THE
EMPEROR, ATRUS
NUL, POSSESSES
THE ROD OF
DUSK.



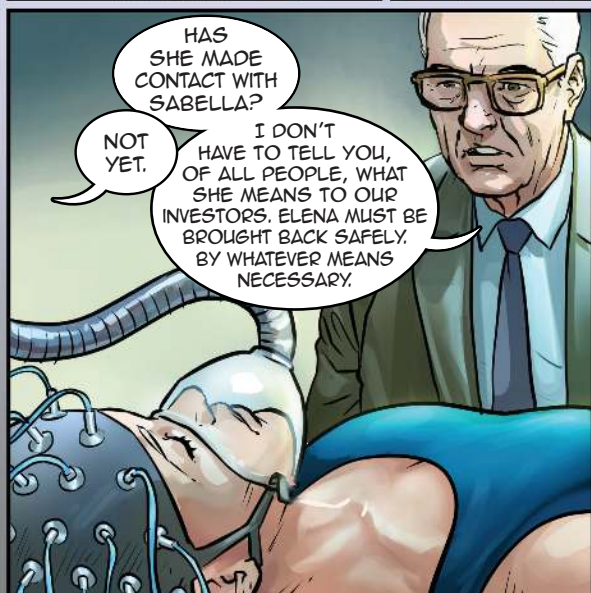


WOW!...
AMAZING LAND-
SCAPE!



HOW IS
SHE?

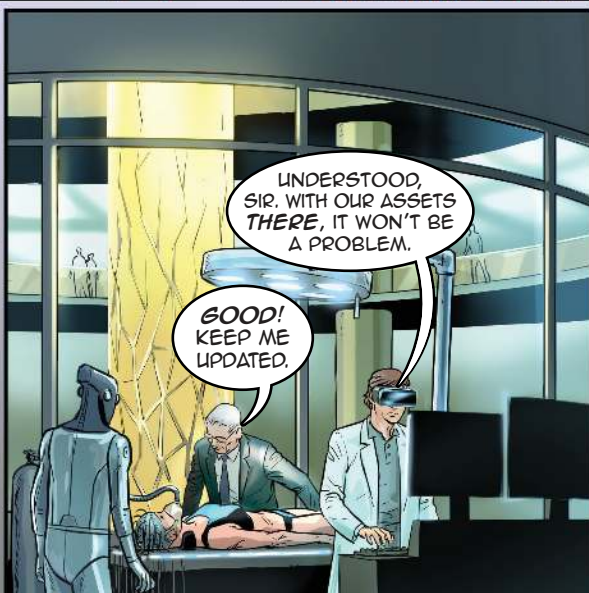
...UM... HEART
BEAT IS A LITTLE
ELEVATED BUT SHE
IS DOING **MUCH**
BETTER THAN THE
OTHERS.



HAS
SHE MADE
CONTACT WITH
SABELLA?

NOT
YET.

I DON'T
HAVE TO TELL YOU,
OF ALL PEOPLE, WHAT
SHE MEANS TO OUR
INVESTORS. ELENA MUST BE
BROUGHT BACK SAFELY.
BY WHATEVER MEANS
NECESSARY.



UNDERSTOOD,
SIR. WITH OUR ASSETS
THERE, IT WON'T BE
A PROBLEM.

GOOD!
KEEP ME
UPDATED.



Heart beat 120... she has arrived.

ELENA?!
ELENA?!
TIME TO WAKE
UP! WE ARE
HERE!